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Block Diagramming for Exegesis

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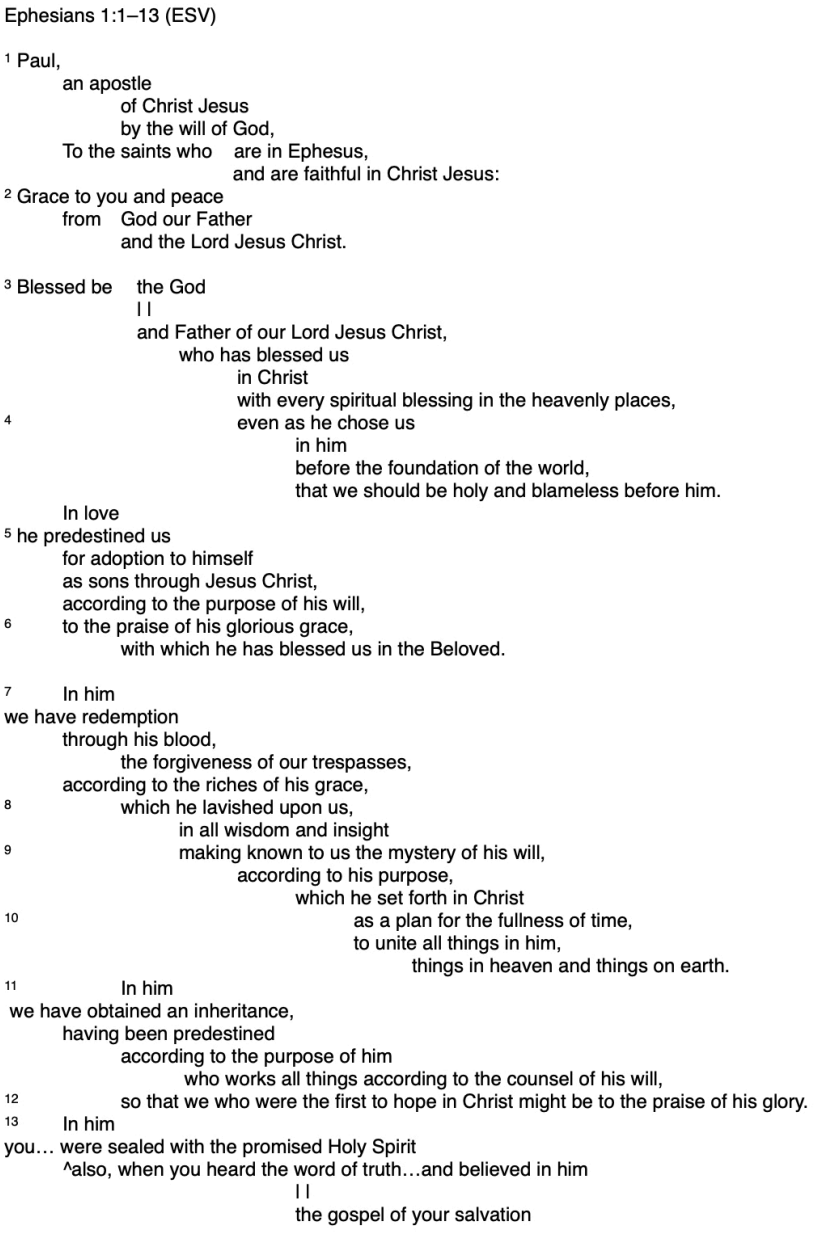
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Section I - What is Block Diagramming?

Block diagramming is a visual way to see the structure of a given sentence or paragraph. Being able to "envision" the author's main points greatly aids the reader in understanding the big picture of the biblical argument. Let us take for example, the opening of the epistle to the Ephesians. The first fourteen verses of the letter are actually a single sentence in the Greek. In English, we break these up into smaller units so our mind can comprehend them more easily. Reading the first fourteen verses, how do you determine what the main thoughts are? What is Paul really driving at in his opening ?

Verse 14 is left out of the diagram due to space limitations.



Notice the block-like structure of the diagram, hence the name of the method. Looking closely at the above photo, besides the greeting and the eulogy, we see four main thoughts in the opening of this epistle. The main thoughts of these verses are (1) we are predestined, ***vv. 5-6***, (2) we have redemption in Christ, ***vv. 7-10*** (3) we have an inheritance, ***vv. 11-12***, and (4) we are sealed for redemption ***v. 13-14***. Block diagramming only has two main rules: main points stay at the left margin while subordinating points are indented to the right. The farther to the right they are indented, the more subordinate they become. However, this does not mean they are less important. The subordinate thoughts explain the main thoughts. It simply means this is how we determine what a main thought is and what a subordinating thought is. All main thoughts are to the far left (ignore any ellipses. They are discussed later) and any subordinating thoughts are indented to the right.

When we read long sentences, it can be difficult to pick out these main thoughts. But seeing them laid out in a visual way such as a block diagram, helps us see how the author moves from argument to argument and supports his main argument with things such as means/manner, cause/effect, purpose, time, etc. All subordinating phrases and clauses will usually fall into any number of given semantic categories. These categories help us sort out the grammar and logic of a passage. As such, it is important that we grasp basic grammatical concepts. It seems like a tedious chore to have to relearn grammar but nonetheless it is absolutely vital if we are going to be good students of God's word and rightly divide His precepts and commands. It is especially important if you teach, knowing that God judges more sternly those who profess to pass on the knowledge of His word.

Don't think of learning grammar as a chore. Think of it as honoring God and as something that God is pleased with. In his short thirty-five page booklet, *Biblical Exegesis*, pastor and author John Piper, states,

> *An evangelical believes that God humbled himself not only in the incarnation of the Son, but also in the inspiration of the Scriptures. The manger and the cross were not sensational. Neither are grammar and syntax. But that is how God chose to reveal himself. A poor Jewish peasant and a prepositional phrase have this in common, they are both human and both ordinary. That the poor peasant was God and the prepositional phrase is the Word of God does not change this fact. Therefore, if God humbled himself to take on human flesh and to speak human language, woe to us if we arrogantly presume to ignore the humanity of Christ and the grammar of Scripture.*[1]

Grammar, in all its dull, ordinary and mundane obtuseness, is valuable. To simply shirk it off because we think it unnecessary or boring is to shrug with contempt true biblical exegesis. I am certainly not suggesting that ability to absorb grammar necessitates love of God and His word. Those who have the ability to learn are obligated to do so and to help those who have not the ability. It indeed seems daunting but is a part of loving your neighbor as yourself.

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[1] John Piper, Biblical Exegesis, p. 5, courtesy of DesiringGod.org

Section II - Basic Grammatical Concepts

Writing is typically divided into two different kinds of units: ***clauses*** and ***phrases***. Understanding grammar begins with these two concepts. Grammatically, a clause is a group of words that *always* contain a subject and a verb. A phrase is a group of words that contains neither a subject or a verb. The following illustration points out the difference between a clause and a phrase:

Jesus is King of the world.

In the simple sentence above we have both a clause and a phrase. *Jesus is King*, is a clause because it contains both a subject, *Jesus*, and an accompanying verb, *is*. The second part of the sentence is a phrase, it contains neither a subject or a verb but simply provides more information about Jesus. It tells us the domain of His reign, *of the world*. This particular type of phrase is called a prepositional phrase. The different types of phrases will be discussed in a later section.

Clauses are also divided into the two categories of ***independent*** or ***dependent***. Independent clauses can stand alone. They will always form a complete sentence. Dependent clauses must have another clause coupled with them in order to make sense. Consider the following example:

God loved the world by sending His Son, Jesus.

The above illustration contains both an independent and dependent clause. The first clause, *God loved the world*, can stand alone and make sense on its own. The second clause, *by sending His Son, Jesus*, is dependent or subordinate to the first clause because it cannot make sense by itself. You will encounter both types of clauses on a regular basis, so it is important to understand the differences between the two. The two most important things to remember are,

1. Clauses *must* have a subject and verb in order to qualify as a true clause
2. Clauses are *dependent* if they do not make a complete sentence.

Now that we understand the basic premise of clauses and phrases, we must move on to some of the finer details of grammar.

Subjects, Verbs, & Direct Objects

Subjects, verbs, and direct objects are the fundamental building blocks of a sentence; at the very least, you need the first two components to have a genuine sentence. Let's take a little time to define these terms, and then we will look at some helpful tips that will aid us in finding these components throughout a paragraph.

Subject – the subject of the sentence will be the main noun (person, place, thing, or idea) of a particular clause. Remember, a clause must have both a subject and a verb in order to be a true clause. Sometimes, the subject may be implied, and thus, the clause is a single word. For example, in the sentence "*Pray*," the subject is understood as "*you pray*." This is common in imperative verbs. We will learn more about the types of verbs below.

Verb – a verb is a word that shows action, a state of being, or gives a command. A verb can be a single word or made up of a "helper" that will complete the verb's action. Verbs also have two different ***voices***: active and passive. Voice, in this sense, simply means how the action of a verb is portrayed. ***Active*** means the subject performs the action of the verb while ***passive*** means the subject is acted upon by the action of the verb. Let's look at two examples:

Jesus loved the world
Jesus was hated by the world

The first sentence is called the active voice. Jesus is performing the action of love. In the second sentence Jesus is receiving the action of being hated and the verb is therefore said to be passive. Often times a passive verb will be accompanied by a helping verb, which is discussed below.

Direct Object – a direct object is another noun that receives the action of the verb. In other words, it is the noun that the verb directly affects. This is different than a passive verb. Direct objects receive the action, whereas passive verbs still affect the subject of the verb. The easiest way to distinguish a direct object from a passive verb is to see which noun always stays the same. In other words, change the passive verb into an active verb and ask, 'Who or what?' If the noun is the same answer in both the active and the passive, you have your subject. If it changes, you have probably mistaken the subject for the direct object or the opposite. What is the easiest way of determining the direct object? Find the verb first and ask who or what of the verb.

Jesus loved the world. Jesus loved who or what? The world = direct object

Here are some tips for finding the different parts of speech in a sentence:

1. Always start by finding the verb. Verbs are usually the easiest to spot. Most of us can naturally find a verb in a sentence. Finding the verb first will help us find the other parts of speech that we need to find. After finding the verb, we can then proceed to find the other necessary parts of speech.

2. After finding the verb, we can then begin to ask questions about that verb to find the other parts of speech. We may ask, "Who or what performed the action?" Using our example sentence above, we could ask, "*Who or what loved?*" The answer is 'Jesus.' Therefore, Jesus is the subject.
3. To find the direct object, we can ask 'Who or what?' once again. The only difference is that we use the subject and ask, who or what? Jesus loved who or what? The answer is the world. If the sentence was passive we would simply ask who or what was loved by Jesus. The 'world' would still be the direct object.

All of these skills, like any other, take practice. Try reading some Scripture and see if you can pick out the subject and verb of each sentence. Don't be discouraged if you don't get it right away. Keep practicing at it and eventually you will become proficient.

Types of Verbs

The last thing we need to discuss before moving on to types of phrases are the kinds of verbs we will encounter. Recognizing the different types of verbs is extremely important! In block diagramming, you will need to find the main verb of a clause/sentence in order to diagram the passage correctly. This involves knowing and understanding the different types of verbs.

Finite verbs

A finite verb is a verb that has a subject. In block diagraming, a finite verb is the *only* type of verb that is the main verb of a clause or sentence. Example: *Jesus died for the sins of mankind*. 'Died' is a finite verb that has the subject 'Jesus.' This can be the main thought or verb of the clause. Be warned! Not all finite verbs will be the main clause. We will learn how to distinguish a main clause later on.

Participles

Participles are verbal words that show how an action is carried out. In English, they typically end in 'ing.' Example: *Jesus died for the sin of mankind by giving His life for us*. The verb 'giving' is a participle and explains how the act or purpose of dying.

Infinitives

Infinitives are the simple form of the verb with the word 'to' prefixed to the verb. Example: *Jesus died for the sin of mankind to redeem us*. In this example, 'to redeem' is considered the full infinitive.

Auxiliary verbs

Auxiliary verbs are verbs that do not transfer their action to an object. These types of verbs can be finite, but I have included them because it is important to understand them. The clearest example of this type of verb is from John 11:35: *Jesus wept*. Here, 'wept' is the verb, but it has no direct object or it does not transfer any action to another noun.

Helping Verbs

These types of verbs "help" to complete the action of the main verb. They are usually made up of several words. Example: J*esus would not be tempted, but entrusted Himself to the Father*. In this example, 'would be tempted' is considered to be the full verb. Just saying 'Jesus tempted' would not have been sufficient. The helping words 'would be' were added to complete the entire idea.

Stative Verbs

Stative verbs are also called state-of-being verbs. They show a state or condition of something.

Example: *Jesus is God in the flesh*. Here, the word 'is' shows the state or reality of Jesus' Deity.

I can't stress the importance of being able to recognize the types of verbs. It may seem a little daunting at first, but with practice, things will become much easier.

Subject/Verb Agreement

A verb is said to ***agree*** with its subject when everything matches. A subject must match its verb in ***person***, ***number***, and ***tense***. The person is who is acting or being acted upon. We refer to person as first person (I, we, our, etc.), second person (you/ya'll), and third person (he, she, them, etc.). The number of a subject/verb simply means whether the word is singular or plural. And finally, tense refers to the time the action is being performed. It will be either present, past, or future. If you are a native English speaker, these will come naturally to you and you should have no problem grasping the concept. Let's look at a quick demonstration of putting the concept into practice:

In the sentence *the apostles taught the word of God*, we can easily pick out the verb, 'taught.' The tense is past since the action has already occurred, but if we change the tense to present, the verb will change: *the apostles are teaching the word of God.* Likewise, if we change the subject from plural to singular, the verb must change to match the subject: *the apostle is teaching the word of God.* Note how the verb changed from *are teaching* to *is teaching.* This is because the subject's person changed and the verb changed to agree with the subject. Agreement simply means that the words change when another one of the sentences's components change in person (first, second, third), number (singular or plural), or tense (past, present, or future).

Types of Phrases

Note: I will be using the word 'phrase' and 'clause' interchangeably as some of the illustrations will show. Even though clauses and phrases differ grammatically, it is easier to refer to both using either term.

We are now diving into the meat of block diagramming. In this tutorial we are going to learn the different types of phrases and how they work within a sentence to give it meaning. While the main clause states what the author is focusing on, phrases help elaborate and flesh out the main idea. Think of it like a map. On a map, key cities are marked by little black dots, the main point. The lines leading up to the cities show the routes that lead to each one, the supporting or subordinating point. The biblical writers wrote the same way. They express the main point and then flesh it out, showing the routes, or logic by which they arrived at their conclusions. Sometimes they would even start with a supporting idea and work their way to the main point, a reverse type of logic.

We see the same principle worked out in academia. When academics write papers for publication they usually start with a thesis statement. It can be as simple as a single sentence or an entire paragraph. Everything after this thesis statement is used to support the main idea. Without the supporting statements the main idea would simply remain something that is unsubstantiated. This is why I say that phrases, which help explain the biblical authors' thoughts, are the meat of block diagramming! Now we will discuss the different types of phrases. All the types of phrases used for illustration will be underlined for easier recognition.

Prepositional Phrase

A prepositional phrase is a phrase containing one of the common prepositions and its object, referred to as the object of the preposition. It's basic function is to show the relationship of one noun to another noun.

Example: Jesus died <u>on a cross</u>.

The word 'on' shows the relationship between 'Jesus' and 'cross.' Prepositions show these relationships in several categories:

1. motion towards its object *(Jesus went **to** the cross*)
2. motion away from its object *(Jesus rose **from** the grave)*
3. location of its object *(Jesus was **on** the cross)*
4. agent or instrument of the object *(Jesus saved us **by/through** His blood)*
5. reason of the object *(Jesus saved us **because of** God's love)*
6. time of the object (Jesus came into Jerusalem ***during*** the Passover)

Sometimes prepositions are comprised of more than one word. These are known as compound prepositions. The most common are:

- according to
- because of
- in front of
- by way of

- on account of
- next to

When you encounter a compound preposition count it as a single word preposition.

Genitive Phrase

A genitive phrase is a phrase which begins with the English word 'of.' Like prepositional phrases they show a relationship to a noun. Most often times a genitive phrase is used to show some type of possession. They differ slightly from prepositional phrases in that they don't have an object because the phrase itself is considered an object and points back to a single noun.

Example: the blood <u>of Jesus</u>

The words 'of Jesus' is considered to be the entire genitive and points back to the the noun ‘blood.' Similar to prepositional phrases, genitive phrases are also categorized. According to *Greek Grammar Beyond the Basics,* there are at least fifteen categories (pp.76-136). The extent of these categories is much too broad for the scope of this tutorial. It is sufficient enough for our purposes simply to be able to identify the genitive phrase.[2]

One cautionary word, be careful to distinguish a genitive phrase from a prepositional phrase that begins with ‘of.’ It is difficult in English to determine which is a genitive and which is a preposition. When in doubt, go with the genitive phrase when possible or check your original language recourses.

Participial Phrase

A participial phrase is a phrase that contains a participial verbal. These types of phrases usually convey ***how*** an action is carried out.

Example: <u>Dying</u> on a cross, Jesus saved the world.

The participle 'dying' shows how the action of saving occurred. It is often referred to as an instrumental means. Participial phrases are most times subservient to the main verb. In our example, the verb 'dying' is subordinate to the main verb of the sentence 'saved.' Most times they function adjectivally or adverbially. Context is usually the best way to tell how a participle is functioning. Some grammarians would make a distinction between a participle and a gerund, which functions like a noun. This tutorial categorizes them as substantivals, instead. Substantivals are discussed below.

Appositional Phrase

An appositional phrase is a phrase which further explains or renames the noun already mentioned

[2] Dan Wallace, 1996, Zondervan Publishing House, pp. 76-136



Example: Jesus, the Son of God, came to save the world.

The phrase 'Son of God' is renaming, or clarifying further, Jesus' identity. You will encounter these many times during the greetings of an epistle. Note also, that our phrase is both appositional as well as genitive. Be aware of common constructions like this when you are block diagramming.

Unmarked (Asyndeton) Phrase

Unmarked, also called ***Asyndeton***, is a phrase which has no apparent connection to the preceding clauses or phrases. Most phrases will have some kind of indicator such as a conjunction, relative pronoun, or other word to indicate a switch. Unmarked phrases do not.

Example: She will bear a son.

The above phrase has no real connection with any other part of speech in the preceding phrases. Often times these types of phrases will be the main phrase or clause of sentence.

Infinitive Phrase

An Infinitive phrase is a phrase with the word 'to' attached to the basic form of a verb.

Example: Jesus came to save sinners.

The phrase 'to save' is our infinitive phrase. Infinitives are often used to show purpose, intent, or the result of an action. Care should be taken when analyzing infinitives.

Conjunctive Phrase

Conjunctive phrases are phrases that begin with one of the coordinating conjunctions.

Example: She will bear a son and you shall call his name, Jesus.

You can clearly see how the conjunction 'and' connects the first clause with the second clause. Their main function is simply to connect other phrases and clauses in order to keep the flow of thought going. Conjunctive phrases are also used to identify lists or contrasts. We will learn more about lists in another section.

Relative Phrase (back)

Relative phrases always begin with a relative pronoun. In English these are who, whom, whose, whoever, which, and sometimes, that.

Example: Jesus is the one who saved the world.

The relative pronoun, like other pronouns, will most times have an ***antecedent***. An antecedent means that the pronoun points back to the person, place, or thing that was previously mentioned. In our example above the relative pronoun 'who' points back to its antecedent, 'Jesus.'

Sometimes the word 'that' functions as a relative pronoun. There is a simple test in order to determine how it is functioning. Simply replace the word 'that' with the proper relative pronoun. If it still makes sense then it is a relative pronoun. If it cannot make sense it is functioning as a demonstrative pronoun. Using our example above we can say, *Jesus is the one that saved the world*. If we replace 'that' with the word 'who' the sentence still makes sense.

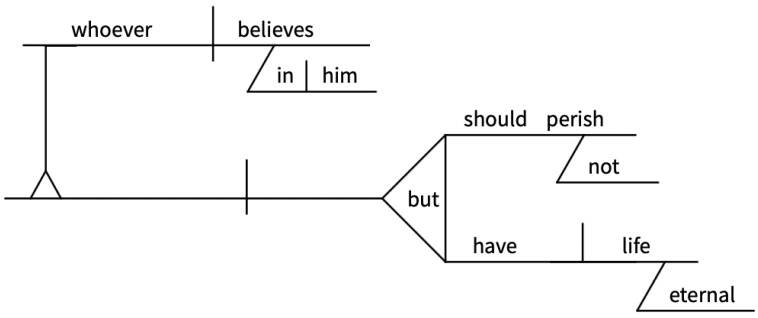
Substantival Phrases

These are probably the toughest of all phrases to identify. Substantival phrases act as nouns but contain a verb. They are very tricky to spot but there is one major way of identifying a substantival: most substantival phrases begin with a relative pronoun. If the pronoun is not connected to an antecedent, it may be a substantival clause. Use care when distinguishing a relative clause from a substantival clause. Often times the relative pronoun's antecedent may be several lines away. Most times it will almost directly follow the noun it is attached to but this is not a hard-fixed rule.

Example: Whoever believes in Him shall not perish but have everlasting life.

In the example of the famous verse, John 3:16, the underlined phrase is acting substantively. That is, the entire clause is functioning as a single part of speech of a noun, in this case, the subject of the clause.

In a traditional sentence diagram the entire clause would sit on top of a stilt in the subject slot to show that it is working together to perform a single unit, as per the photo below.



We will not be constructing diagrams like the above photo. It is simply an illustration to show how the substantival functions as a single part of speech. Substantival clauses can function in any capacity that a

noun can. This means they can be the subject, direct object, object of a preposition, etc. Examine them closely to determine whether you have a true relative clause or a substantival clause.

Conditional Phrase

A conditional phrase gives us the circumstances under which something is true or false. In Romans 13:4, the apostle Paul states, *if you do wrong, be afraid*. This is an example of a conditional phrase. Conditionals consists of two parts: the protasis (if…) and the apodosis (then…) If this…then that. In a conditional phrase the protasis will always be subordinate to the apodosis. Also be aware that the apodosis sometimes comes first. Even if the order is reversed, subordination will still be the same.

Section III - Propositions

In the book, *Interpreting the Pauline Epistles,* Thomas Schreiner defines for us what a ***proposition*** is.

> What is a proposition? A proposition is an assertion or statement about something. The words "she ate" form a proposition, for it makes a statement or an assertion about something. To be a proposition, a statement must have a subject and predicate. The subject or predicate can be implied. If my child were to run toward the street, I would yell, "Stop!" The one word "stop" is a proposition because the implied subject is "you," and the imperative verb "stop" is the predicate.[3]

The definition seems a bit vague, but it really is that simple. A proposition is simply a statement that contains both a subject and a verb. In other words, a proposition is a clause. Sometimes, marking propositions will not be as simple as finding a subject and verb. A proposition will contain a subject and verb, but it will also contain all of its other components such as prepositional phrases and genitive phrases. Some propositions may expand several lines if you decide to keep all phrases intact with their subject and verb. 1Peter 1:1-2 provides a good example of this.

> *1 Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, To those who are elect exiles of the Dispersion in Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia, 2 according to the foreknowledge of God the Father, in the sanctification of the Spirit, for obedience to Jesus Christ and for sprinkling with his blood: May grace and peace be multiplied to you.*

Several prepositional phrases are a part of this single sentence. Of course, they can be broken off into individual propositions if one chooses, though it does not technically fit the rigid definition of what a proposition is. Unlike traditional diagramming, Block Diagramming is flexible enough to allow for user-friendly caveats such as "customizable" propositions. The only two major rules to follow is that main

[3] Schreiner, T. R. (2011). *Interpreting the Pauline Epistles* (Second Edition). Baker Academic, p. 99 Logos Edition

propositions remain at the left margin while subordinating propositions are indented to the right underneath the main propositions, as we discussed in the introduction.

How To Break Up Propositions

Step 1 - Determine the limits of your passage

Before we can even start breaking a passage apart, we must first find the passage's boundaries. Many times the boundaries will be an entire paragraph, or what is known as a ***pericope (per-ik-o-pee)***. A pericope is a single-unit of thought. The author focuses on a single idea and develops the idea for one or more paragraphs. Our opening example of Ephesians 1:1-14 is a fine demonstration of a single pericope. If you read the passage closely, you will notice that Paul starts a new thought, or unit, in verse 15 with the words, *For this reason*. When an author transitions from one thought to another, there are usually key words which can be honed in on. Especially be on the look out for phrases like the one above, conjunctions, or other transitionary words that signal a new thought. Just be aware that a new thought does not always mean chapter divisions. Our modern bibles use chapter and verse divisions for convenience but the ancient biblical writers knew of no such thing. Using Ephesians as an example again, one will find that the next section after verse 14 expands from chapter 1, verse 15 until chapter 2, verse 10. Don't let your mind disengage the topic when you come to a new chapter. Sometimes a new chapter does indicate a new thought, but not always.

It can be difficult to see transitions even when we read slowly. There are tools available to help us sort out the boundaries of Scripture pericopes. A simple search for *paragraph transitional words* yielded the following PDF from the University of Southern Florida. Feel free to download and use it in your own study.

Transitional Words

Step 2 - Identify each phrase/clause and begin to break up the passage

It is helpful to see the small individual chunks and focus on each one rather than focusing on the whole paragraph at once. Several things will help in breaking down your chosen passage. This section will help identify and aid the reader in knowing how, when, and why to split a clause where it needs to be split. We will try and use an actual passage for this step to facilitate learning.

Breaking a passage apart into individual propositions begins with what we learned at the beginning of step 2. We must first identify each individual clause and put it on a new line. If you remember from our brief grammar lesson, we learned that a clause is a group of words with at least a subject and a verb and that it can be either independent or dependent. This step will have several sub steps that will make it easier and more efficient.

You should have already determined the boundaries of your passage before you begin this step. For our example passage we will use 2Peter 1:3-15. It is short but challenging. I will be using the ESV translation for the remainder of the tutorial. You may use whichever translation suits you.

> 3 His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge
> of him who called us to his own glory and excellence, 4 by which he has granted to us his precious and
> very great promises, so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature, having
> escaped from the corruption that is in the world because of sinful desire. 5 For this very reason, make
> every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, 6 and knowledge with self-
> control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, 7 and godliness with
> brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love. 8 For if these qualities are yours and are
> increasing, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ.
> 9 For whoever lacks these qualities is so nearsighted that he is blind, having forgotten that he was
> cleansed from his former sins. 10 Therefore, brothers, be all the more diligent to confirm your calling and
> election, for if you practice these qualities you will never fall. 11 For in this way there will be richly
> provided for you an entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. 12 Therefore
> I intend always to remind you of these qualities, though you know them and are established in the truth
> that you have. 13 I think it right, as long as I am in this body, to stir you up by way of reminder, 14 since I
> know that the putting off of my body will be soon, as our Lord Jesus Christ made clear to me. 15 And I will
> make every effort so that after my departure you may be able at any time to recall these things.

Step 2.1 - begin with the first full sentence

When doing any type of diagramming, we must take the entire sentence as a whole. Sometimes a sentence may be a single command or sometimes it may stretch out over several verses. Each sentence goes on a line by itself. In 2Peter 1:3, the first sentence is shown below.

3 His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of him who called us to his own glory and excellence, **4** by which he has granted to us his precious and very great promises, so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature, having escaped from the corruption that is in the world because of sinful desire.

5 For this very reason, make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, **6** and knowledge with self-control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, **7** and godliness with brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love. **8** For if these qualities are yours and are increasing, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. **9** For whoever lacks these qualities is so nearsighted that he is blind, having forgotten that he was cleansed from his former sins. **10** Therefore, brothers, be all the more diligent to confirm your calling and election, for if you practice these qualities you will never fall. **11** For in this way there will be richly provided for you an entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. **12** Therefore I intend always to remind you of these qualities, though you know them and are established in the truth that you have. **13** I think it right, as long as I am in this body, to stir you up by way of reminder, **14** since I know that the putting off of my body will be soon, as our Lord Jesus Christ made clear to me. **15** And I will make every effort so that after my departure you may be able at any time to recall these things.

You can clearly see the first full sentence (v.3-4) on a single line with the rest of the passage underneath. Once we have isolated the first sentence, we move on to the clause's other phrases and clauses. There are a total of eighteen propositions in this first full sentence. Can you find each one? Here is a little hint: **3** relative clauses, **8** prepositional phrases, **2** genitive phrases, **2** asyndeton (unmarked) clauses, **1** participle phrase, **1** conjunctive phrase, and the main clause which makes a total of eighteen.

3 His divine power has granted to us all things
that pertain
to life and godliness,
through the knowledge
of him
who called us
to his own glory and excellence,
4 by which
he has granted to us
his precious and very great promises,
so that
through them
you may become partakers
of the divine nature,
having escaped
from the corruption
that is
in the world
because of sinful desire.

5 For this very reason, make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, **6** and knowledge with self-control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, **7** and godliness with brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love. **8** For if these qualities are yours and are increasing, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. **9** For whoever lacks these qualities is so nearsighted that he is blind, having forgotten that he was cleansed from his former sins. **10** Therefore, brothers, be all the more diligent to confirm your calling and election, for if you practice these qualities you will never fall. **11** For in this way there will be richly provided for you an entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. **12** Therefore I intend always to remind you of these qualities, though you know them and are established in the truth that you have. **13** I think it right, as long as I am in this body, to stir you up by way of reminder, **14** since I know that the putting off of my body will be soon, as our Lord Jesus Christ made clear to me. **15** And I will make every effort so that after my departure you may be able at any time to recall these things.

A little side note, not every phrase needs its own line. I am going through the formal process so that you will learn to recognize each type of phrase and clause. Keeping the two major rules of block diagramming in mind, main clauses at the left margin and subordinating clauses indented to the right, this method of study can be tailored to your own need. Not every phrase will bear exegetical weight. The helpful book, *How To Understand And Apply The New Testament,* Bible teacher, Andy Nasalli notes,

> When you are [block diagramming] a passage of Scripture, you don't have to fastidiously place every single proposition or phrase on its own line. It's a judgment call. For example, Schreiner shares, "I usually do not make a new proposition with the relative clause unless I deem the relative clause to be particularly significant exegetically." I agree. Sometimes I place a prepositional phrase on its own line, and sometimes I keep it together with a bigger clause. Sometimes I break up an if-then statement to two lines, and sometimes I keep it on one line. It depends on how exegetically significant a phrase is or if there are several parallel phrases that would be helpful to display on a series of parallel lines. The main thing is that your phrasing diagram graphically depicts the flow of thought well.[4]

Taking this into consideration, we can clean up our propositions to reflect something that is a little more unified. We then have something like this:

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[4] Naselli, A. D. (2017). How to Understand and Apply the New Testament: Twelve Steps from Exegesis to Theology. P&R Publishing, p. 136

3 His divine power has granted to us
all things that pertain to life and godliness,
through the knowledge
of him who called us
to his own glory and excellence,
4 by which
he has granted to us
his precious and very great promises,
so that through them
you may become partakers of the divine nature,
having escaped
from the corruption that is in the world
because of sinful desire.

We have now knocked our eighteen propositions down to thirteen! If needed, we could condense them more, but for now we will leave it as is. The important take away is that you do not have to be so rigid in breaking apart a passage unless you deem it particularly helpful to do so.

Step 2.2 - identify the main clause of the sentence

The main clause will be something like the thesis statement of the author. He will state a main point and use subordinating clauses to develop or argue his point. Sometimes it will be reversed. The supporting points will come first and the main point follows as a tie-in to the theology of the point. How do we determine what the main clause is? We must rely on the grammar of the passage to tell us. This is why we spent the first portion of this tutorial refreshing ourselves on the basics of grammar. There are clues in the grammar itself that will help us determine what the main clause of a sentence will be:

1. A main clause can *only* contain a ***finite*** verb. A finite verb is a verb that will change to match its subject in person, number, and tense. Refer to the section on subject/verb agreement above to refresh your memory.
2. A finite verb does *not* necessarily mean that it is a main clause. Be aware of this fact and look for transitionary conjunctions. A transitionary conjunction with a finite verb that follows in a clause will typically mean the clause is subordinate rather than the main clause.
3. A main clause will never contain a verbal (participle, infinitive) *unless* the verbal is functioning substantively: *to live is Christ and to die is gain.* The underlined portion shows how the infinitive is acting as a noun to the stative verb, *is*.
4. Relative clauses will not be a main clause *unless* it is formed into a question.
5. A main clause will stand alone as a complete sentence.
6. A main clause may be a single imperative command.
7. Make sure you keep the subject, verb, and object on the same line. Splitting them up can cause confusion during the indenting process.

In the example Scripture above, 2Peter 1:3-4 contains the main clause, *his divine power has granted to us all things*.[5] We have determined this because everything else that follows is either a relative clause or has a transitionary conjunction or adverb that makes it dependent on the main clause. Since relative clauses or clauses with transitionary conjunctions can't be the main clause, this is the only other clause that remains. Therefore, this clause will stay at the left margin. All other clauses and phrases will be indented at different levels underneath of this clause.

Before we move on I would like to illustrate number 2 on our main clause hints list regarding the presence of a finite verb within a clause not necessitating a main clause. There are actually finite verbs in the propositions *you may become partakers of the divine nature* and *he has granted to us his very precious and great promises*. At least in the Greek, both of these contain finite verbs. Remember to check for your transitionary words before determining if the finite verb you're looking at is the main verb of the sentence.

Step 2.3 - begin to indent the subordinating elements

Since we have our fist full sentence we will begin to indent the sentence's other clauses and phrases. Ultimately the question arises, how do I know where to indent them? Many people like to indent them under the word the clause modifies, like the example below.

3 His divine power has granted to us
all things that pertain to life and godliness,
through the knowledge
of him who called us
to his own glory and excellence,
4 by which
he has granted to us
his precious and very great promises,
so that through them
you may become partakers of the divine nature,
having escaped
from the corruption that is in the world
because of sinful desire.

The clause modifies the verb *has granted* and has been indented underneath of it. This is typically a good rule of thumb because you get a little closer to the grammar of the passage, but you will quickly find that you run out of space fast. My own habit is to indent a few spaces underneath the preceding clause. If there is any exegetical insight to the actual word to which the phrase is subordinate, I make a note of it and keep it for any teaching or preaching outline.

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[5] In Greek, this is actually a subordinate clause called a Genitive Absolute. However, our English translations leave out the subordinating conjunction as the construction seems to be acting finitely.

Another question is how do I know I'm indenting it correctly? When we are block diagramming it can become apparent if phrases and clauses are subordinated correctly by reading the main clause or head clause/phrase first and then the subordinating clause/phrase to see if it makes sense in that spot. Let's try this with our next phrase, *through the knowledge of him who called us*.

3 His divine power has granted to us
all things that pertain to life and godliness,
through the knowledge

At first glance, it may appear that the prepositional phrase has been indented correctly. But when we drill down a little deeper we will see that it doesn't quite fit in that spot. To determine if *things that pertain to life and godliness* is where our prepositional phrase should be indented, we read the main clause first:

His divine power has granted to us
things that pertain to life and godliness

Now, we read the next phrase and test our subordination.
things that pertain to life and godliness
through the knowledge of Him who called us

We must ask ourselves if the things of life and godliness grant us knowledge of God or if the knowledge of God comes some other way. In the strictest grammatical sense, the preposition *through* often indicates means or manner, making it an adverbial modifier. Therefore, the subordination may fit better like such,

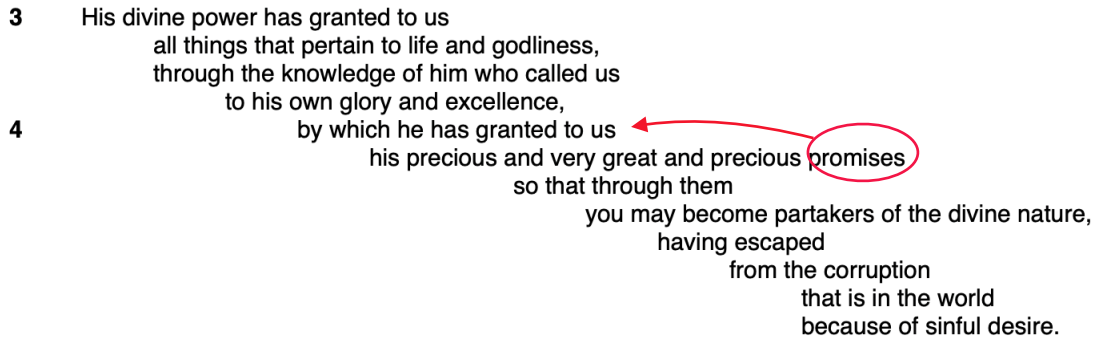
3 His divine power has granted to us
all things that pertain to life and godliness,
through the knowledge of him who called us

The phrase seems to fit much better indented at the same level as the preceding phrase. Now when we read our diagram, it makes sense: His divine power has granted what? All things that pertain to life and godliness. His divine power has granted life and godliness how? Through the knowledge of him who called us. Make it a practice to read your diagram often throughout this process, checking your subordination as you go. Now let's put this into practice and indent the rest of our phrases and clauses.

3 His divine power has granted to us
all things that pertain to life and godliness,
through the knowledge of him who called us
to his own glory and excellence,
4 by which he has granted… ^promises,
^to us
his precious and very great…
so that through them
you may become partakers of the divine nature,
having escaped
from the corruption
that is in the world
because of sinful desire.

Step 2.4 - make any adjustments to your subordinate elements

You may have noticed the circled portion with the arrow pointing back to the previous line. That is because the circled word is the direct object of the verb *granted* and should be kept on the same line. This is the step where we make those kinds of adjustments. It is also one of the issues you will run into frequently when diagramming a text. Adjectives, adverbs, prepositional phrases, and other modifiers often come between a subject and a verb or its object. To keep them together and still show that the word order has been modified, we use an ellipses (…) and a caret mark (^). This shows any one viewing your diagram that adjustments were made in order to allow subordination to be shown. Let's make those adjustments now.



Note that I rearranged phrases in two different places. I moved the indirect object *to us* underneath the verb and then moved the direct object up to the same line as the verb. Of course, this is purely a user decision. I decided not to do it with the main clause. It's totally up to you.

But note one other thing: I indented the adjective phrase *his great and precious* underneath *promises*. This was so there would be no confusion as to what this phrase is modifying. When you have words or phrases that modify two different elements on the same line, it would be a wise to subordinate them accordingly. This cuts down on confusion, especially if you have to leave your diagram for a couple of days before you have a chance to come back and complete it. Let's diagram the rest of the passage. Following the steps above, break up and subordinate verses 5-11.

3 His divine power has granted to us
all things that pertain to life and godliness,
through the knowledge of him who called us
to his own glory and excellence,
4 by which he has granted… ^promises,
^to us
his precious and very great…
so that through them
you may become partakers of the divine nature,
having escaped
from the corruption
that is in the world
because of sinful desire.

5 For this very reason, make every effort to supplement your faith
with virtue,
and virtue
with knowledge,
6 and knowledge
with self-control,
and self-control
with steadfastness,
and steadfastness
with godliness,
7 and godliness
with brotherly affection,
and brotherly affection
with love.

8 For if these qualities are yours
and are increasing,
they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful
in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ.

9 For whoever lacks these qualities
is so nearsighted that he is blind,
having forgotten that he was cleansed from his former sins.

10 Therefore, brothers, be all the more diligent to confirm your calling and election,
for if you practice these qualities
you will never fall.

11 For in this way there will be richly provided for you an entrance
into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

Section IV - Semantic Labeling

Semantics have to do with how words relate to one another. In block diagramming we are concerned with how each subordinate phrase is related to the main clause. We are seeking to understand how each proposition relates to the main clause via means, purpose, time, result, etc. This is where semantic labels play their role. All the biblical authors had specific goals in mind when they wrote to their audiences. Although they did not purposely write to "label" the meanings of their syntax, they no doubt wrote with purpose and authority. In short, semantic labeling is simply a way of adding tags to show the relationships of each proposition to its main clause. This section hopes to define each label and give clear definitions of syntactical meanings behind then.

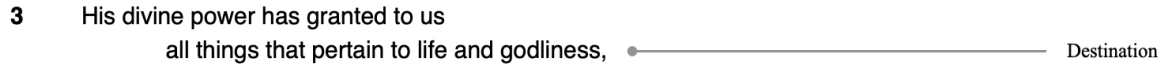
The key to identifying relationships lies in transitionary conjunctions and prepositions. For example, the preposition *through* often indicates means or manner while the conjunction *when* will point out a time period under which the main action occurs. This is why it is important to read carefully and

note these little words. They can have a big impact on your interpretation! Below, you will find two PDF's which are provided through Biblearc.com. Biblearc is a website and application dedicated to helping people become better students of God's word. One of the modules they provide is Block Diagramming, which they call Phrasing. The first PDF shows the diagramming relationships. The second shows all the English conjunctions along with their associated semantic possibilities for their respective head clauses and phrases.

Block Diagramming (Phrasing) Cheat Sheet
English Conjunctions Cheat Sheet

Before we talk more about semantic labeling, we must explain the labeling process. There are basically two rules for labeling: (1.) main clauses take no label because they stand as the main thought of the sentence. This means all subordinate clauses/phrases will have a label except (2.) relative clauses. An arrow is drawn from the relative pronoun back to its antecedent. If you need help remembering how to find an antecedent please review its corresponding section.

The goal for labeling is to identify *how* the phrase being labeled is connected to the main clause. Most word processors have a means of drawing lines. You can use this feature for labeling. Draw a line from the right-hand margin to the phrase. Use a text box and format the text so that it fits within the margin and connect it to the label. An example can be seen below.



I formatted my word document with 0.5 spaces on all margins and used landscape mode to achieve this outcome. It seems to work well as it gives enough room to use both the lines and label boxes.

Determining the Correct Relationship

Below is the PDF of the relationships you will use in block diagramming. Biblearc has divided these relationships into three categories: support by distinct statement, support by contrary statement, and support by restatement. They have also color-coded the categories for easier recognition. You will also find letters underneath each relationship with the key at the bottom of the PDF. These letters show what *type*s of relationships are associated with each one. You can use the English conjunctions PDF to help determine the relationships. We will look at one of the phrases attached to the main phrase in verse 3: *through the knowledge of him who called us…*

through	Locative	Lk 1:65
	Agency	Jn 1:17
	Means	Ro 7:11

We first look at our conjunctions and prepositions sheet to narrow things down. Our conjunction and prepositions sheet lists everything in alphabetical order to make things easier to find.

This is the step where we will combine both the English conjunction sheet with the Block Diagramming relationship sheet. We see that this particular conjunction is associated with three different relationships. Now we can look at our Relationships sheet and read the description for each possible relationship to see which one fits best for our verse. According to the descriptions of the three relationships, we can definitely rule out Locative since we are not dealing with a location. Of the two remaining, Means seems the best fit as Agency is not in consideration. We would need an actual person mentioned in the phrase before we could consider that relationship. Therefore, we label our phrase means and move to the next phrase.

Block Diagramming Relationships



Obvious Phrases

One thing to keep in mind is that you do not necessarily need to label the phrases in order of the passage. Many times the relationships will be obvious, especially as you get used to the spotting key conjunctions and their associated relationships. For example, the conjunction *so that* will almost always indicate a purpose or result. It is still important, however, to look at all the relationships associated with each conjunction an preposition before jumping to any hasty conclusions. Going through your passage and labeling the obvious phrases first will help streamline your study. You can always return and reevaluate your choices later if something doesn't seem to fit.

There will always be times when a conjunction or preposition doesn't fit neatly into one of the associated relationships. It is here that you will have to make your best guess. You will need to "read between the lines," so to speak, and try to determine what the author is really getting at.

To demonstrate briefly, we can look at verses 5-7 of qualities Peter lists. They are all preceded by the preposition *with*. When we look at our cheat sheet we find that there are only two relationships, Accompaniment and Manner, associated with the conjunction. Although Accompaniment may be a possibility it doesn't seem to fit well with what Peter is communicating. It seems Peter is using these things to state the ***Content*** of what kinds of qualities Christians should possess. In my own labeling, I settled for that relationship rather than Accompaniment. You may find that you have to adjust your labeling from time-to-time. Don't be afraid to do it. The important thing is that you can justify the relationship with the message the author is conveying.

The Main Point: What's The Big Idea? **[go back]**

While block diagramming shows us the author's main thoughts and its flow, we still need to seek out the main point of the passage. What is the big idea the author is trying to convey? It may indeed be in one of the main clauses, but it may also be the topic or several points coming together to focus on a single theme. Romans is a superb example of this! Over several chapters, Paul argues for justification by faith alone as the single topic. If we were to isolate only the main clauses we would miss the big idea: becoming right before God (justification) is not worked for in human righteousness. It is gained by faith in Christ. Paul uses the example of Abraham as the prime example of being justified apart from keeping the Law. The main clauses supporting this idea build to a climax to show this. Certainly, we could apply the several parts and benefit, but still, the main point of Paul's argument is for the sole purpose of showing justification by faith alone.

For the rest of this tutorial, we will focus on how to determine the main point. We will continue to use our passage from 2Peter to illustrate these principles.

A Hierarchy of Argument

We have stated more than once that the biblical authors wrote with a purpose and that they structured their thoughts around this purpose. Yes, there may be several topics and instructions given, and they may form several big ideas. But they may also be building up to one or two things the author wishes his audience to zero in on. This is where good reading comes into play. You may have heard the old saying, context is king. It is absolutely vital that we consider the full context of a passage before determining the main point. Context is usually broken down into three different categories which can be defined as,

1. Book context - what is the purpose for writing the epistle/book?
2. Cultural context - what, if any, cultural uniqueness is present within the book?
3. Immediate context - what do the surrounding verses and the following verses state?

If none of these things is considered first, we interpret in vain. A good habit of hermeneutics is to read the book through in one sitting (if possible) several times before beginning your diagram. Most epistles are short enough to do this. Some will take longer and may be broken up into one or more reading, but as a rule of thumb, you should always try to complete an entire book in one session. In this way, you will gain a basic understanding of how the author is laying out his arguments.

The main point of any given passage will be that topic which all others are centered around. The author will make a statement and then support that statement with several arguments. The arguments will usually culminate to support the central idea of his statement. Ephesians 2:1-10 is a prime example of this. Read it below and try to figure out the main theme. I have left the verse numbers out purposely for undistracted reading.

> *And you were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked, following the course of this world, following the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that is now at work in the sons of disobedience—among whom we all once lived in the passions of our flesh, carrying out the desires of the body and the mind, and were by nature children of wrath, like the rest of mankind. But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ—by grace you have been saved— and raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus, so that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus. For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them.*

If we follow the flow of thought, there are two main statements: ***you were dead in your trespasses*** and ***but God made us alive…and raised us up.*** Everything else is subordinate to these two statements. The conjunction *but* signals what is known as a **contrast**. A contrast compares one thing with the other to

show a particular quality or feature of the main thing. The online Merriam Webster Dictionary words it as, *comparison of similar objects to set off their dissimilar qualities*[6].

In this particular contrast we have a negative quality, death, and a positive quality, life. In what is known as the Laws of Composition (discussed below) the positive side is given more significance than the negative side. Therefore, we conclude that the main point of Ephesians 2:1-10 is God's love for us that causes those who have faith in Christ to be raised up with Christ and be made spiritually alive. Reading the text closely pays large dividends in the end. It may come slowly and the yield may trickle in, at first. But eventually, Gods' Holy Spirit will illumine us and give us understanding. Amen!

The Laws of Composition[7]

When assessing the main point of any paragraph or pericope, there are certain literary features that need to be minded. Osborne and Woodward elaborate.

> Composition" refers to the author's arrangement—his "composing"—of his material. The purpose of "arrangement" is to provide unity. Just as every line and hue of a painting is ordered to advantage the whole, so in a literary composition all the parts are ordered to advantage the whole. One needs to read no farther than the first chapter or two in each of the four Gospels before he detects the different arrangements of material. Matthew begins with Jesus' family tree; John with the pronouncement of His preexistent divinity. Luke opens with the birth of John (1:5ff); Mark begins with Jesus' baptism by John. Though the facts were shared by all, each writer obviously arranged his own data or material to suit his own purpose.[8]

In the simplest terms, composition is the placing of key words and transitions to focus on the author's main theme(s). According to the authors there are ten composition laws to be noted:

- comparison
- contrast
- interchange
- continuity
- continuation
- cause and effect
- progression
- cruciality
- summarization
- interrogation

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[6] See link here for the online definition.

[7] The title of this section is taken from *Handbook For Bible Study* by Grant Osborne & Stephen Woodward.

[8] Osborne, G. R., & Woodward, S. B. (1979). *Handbook for Bible study, pp.67-68,* Baker Book House, Logos Edition.

In each paragraph there are certain things that should be considered primary. Imperatives usually take precedence as they are commands for God's people to do or stop a thing. In a contrast, the positive aspect or quality is to be considered priority. A purpose statement is usually led off with the conjunctions, *that, so that, in order to,* etc. Purpose clauses are typically subordinate to the main clause but not necessarily less important. Determining the main point is more about closer reading to pick out the type of composition laws and then to be able to zero in on the main topic.

Application - What Is The Theology of This Passage?

Without allowing God's word to change us, all of our studies would be in vain. The entire reason we study is to be changed. Our change is wrought only by the Holy Spirit who in turn takes His truths and works them in our lives, living out our faith *coram deo* (before God) and *coram mundo* (before the world).

Application cannot however, be subjective. A passage of Scripture should never be interpreted as, *what this passage means to **ME***. Like interpretation, application follows specific guidelines. There are several things to be considered before making application from your chosen passage.[9]

1. ***The application must be in line with the interpretation***. It would be useless to apply a verse out of its context. In the book *Preaching God's Word*, the authors use the example of how Philippians 4:13, *I can do all things through Christ*, is often abused.

> Duvall and Hays caution you to include all the elements in order to assure an application that is connected to the original meaning of the text. In the Philippians 4:13 example, it is important not to overlook one of the crucial points—Paul was strengthened when he endured persecution while trying to carry out his calling from God. Some people have used this passage to say that God will strengthen them in any difficult situation regardless of the cause. For example, Christian athletes have used this verse to claim strength from God in athletic competition. This "sports" application misses the message of this text because it overlooks one of the critical components of the original situation—Paul's persecution for faithfully trying to follow Christ.[10]

Application used wrongly often results in disillusionment for the person as they wonder why God didn't "keep" His promise. All along, the person misapplied the promise and blamed God. It is crucial the the application for yourself or your audience remain in sync with the meaning to the original audience.

2. ***The application must be derived from the theological principles within the text***. A theological principle is described by the authors as that which transcends time and culture. That is, no matter what culture or time period you live in, the truth of the theological principle will always be valid. It will never change to suit the current culture. In the Philippians 4:13 example above,

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[9] The principles from this section come from chapter 6 of the book *Preaching God's Word*, by Terry Carter, Scott Duvall, & Daniel Hays.

[10] Carter, Terry G.. Preaching God's Word: A Hands-On Approach to Preparing, Developing, and Delivering the Sermon . Zondervan. Kindle Edition.

the theological principle is that God's strength will aid His people in specific times. This principle is derived from the meaning of the text. Paul was imprisoned for his faithfulness in preaching the gospel. He relates how God strengthened him when he abounded in plenty or want, sickness and health. The application therefore would be that God's strength allows a believer to carry on His work no matter if the person is facing persecution, want for material needs, or having what is needed. Paul's contentment in Christ's strength allowed him to faithfully spread the gospel despite being imprisoned.

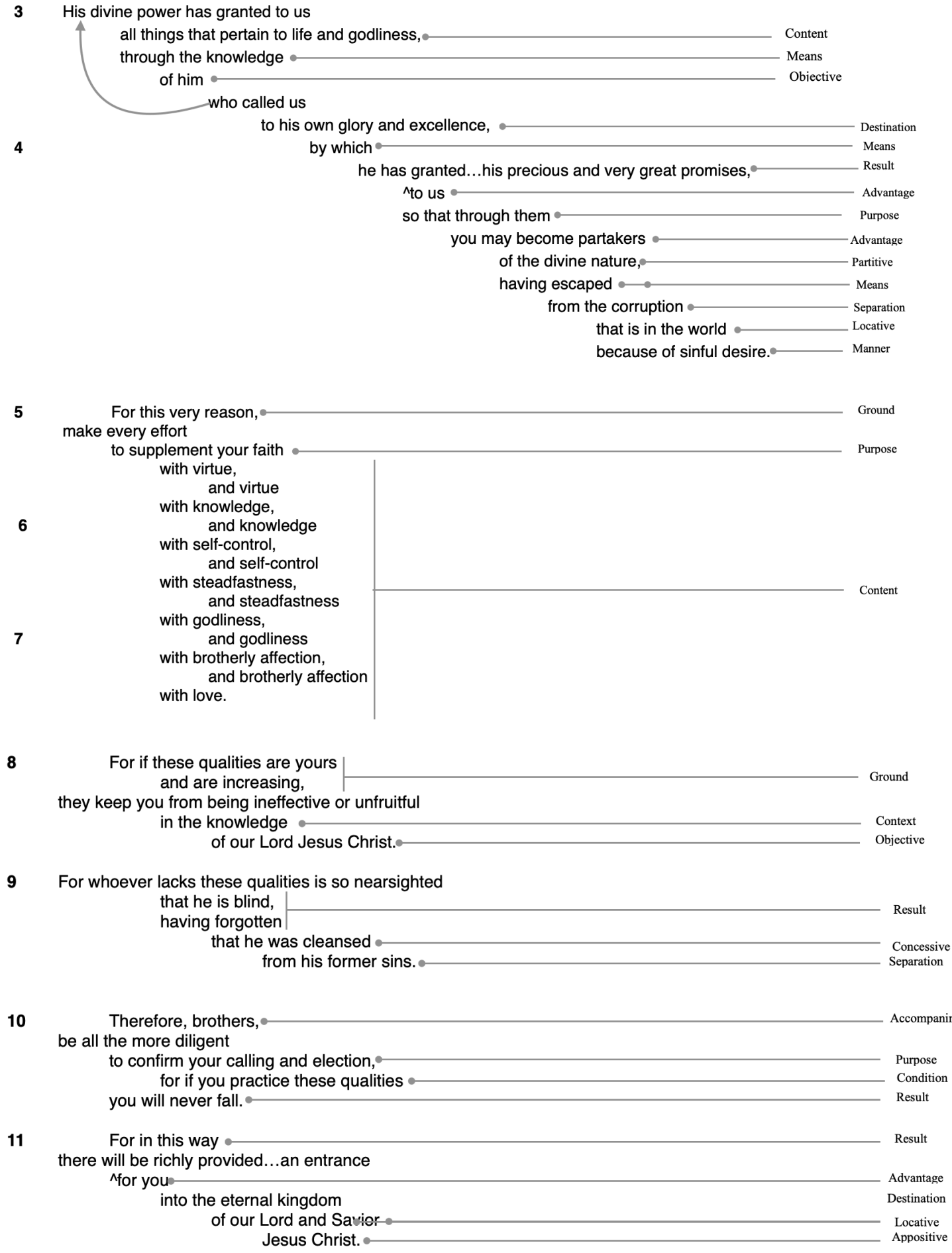
3. ***If the text calls for a specific action, that is the application.***[11] In many didactic (teaching) epistles, an application is already set forth within the text through imperative commands. Imperatives such as love your enemies (Matthew 5:43-48), Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good (Romans 12:21) and Be sober (1Peter 5:8) are applications within the text themselves. If the application is within the text itself, do not complicate matters by adding to them unless it is necessary. Be aware that though the imperatives themselves are applications, the author may still have a bigger theological picture in mind.

Application is the key to sanctification. Application simply means hearing what is commanded and then taking steps to obey. As we obey God's word more and more, the Holy Spirit sanctifies us, separating us out from the world a little farther than previously. And the farther we move away from the world (spiritually) the more glory and excellence of the Godhead we will see and love.

Section V: Practice Example

In this final section we will look at 2Peter 1:3-11, our example passage, as a whole. In an earlier section, I stated that it is not necessary to break each phrase onto its own line. I will however, use that method for the example. While it is not always necessary, it can be helpful because each clause is being broken down to its smallest grammatical uint. Still, feel free to break up the passage accordingly, keeping in mind the two rules of main clauses at the left and subordinating clauses indented underneath to the right. Screenshots of my own diagram are below.

[11] This step was not listed in the book specifically, but the principles for it are mentioned.


3
His divine power has granted to us
all things that pertain to life and godliness,
Content
through the knowledge
Means
of him
Objective
who called us
to his own glory and excellence,
Destination
4
by which
Means
he has granted…his precious and very great promises,
Result
^to us
Advantage
so that through them
Purpose
you may become partakers
Advantage
of the divine nature,
Partitive
having escaped
Means
from the corruption
Separation
that is in the world
Locative
because of sinful desire.
Manner
5
For this very reason,
Ground
make every effort
to supplement your faith
Purpose
with virtue,
and virtue
with knowledge,
6
and knowledge
with self-control,
and self-control
with steadfastness,
and steadfastness
Content
with godliness,
7
and godliness
with brotherly affection,
and brotherly affection
with love.
8
For if these qualities are yours
and are increasing,
Ground
they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful
in the knowledge
Context
of our Lord Jesus Christ.
Objective
9
For whoever lacks these qualities is so nearsighted
that he is blind,
having forgotten
Result
that he was cleansed
Concessive
from his former sins.
Separation
10
Therefore, brothers,
Accompaniment
be all the more diligent
to confirm your calling and election,
Purpose
for if you practice these qualities
Condition
you will never fall.
Result
11
For in this way
Result
there will be richly provided…an entrance
^for you
Advantage
into the eternal kingdom
Destination
of our Lord and Savior
Locative
Jesus Christ.
Appositive

Outline Example

There are six main clauses in the flow of this passage: (1) His divine power has granted all things (2) make every effort to supplement your faith (3) they (the qualities) keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful (4) whoever lacks these qualities is blind (5) be all the more diligent to confirm your calling and election (6) there will be an entrance provided for you. A quick outline of these nine verses could yield something like this:

I. God's divine power has been granted to us…
  A. Things necessary to live a godly life
  B. By personal knowledge of Himself:
    a. He has called us to glory and excellence (virtue)
    b. He has granted His promises
      i. Precious
      ii. Very great (superlative of great)
    c. For the purpose of becoming divine partakers
      i. We have escaped (moral) corruption
        • corruption in the world
        • corruption that comes through lustful desires.

II. Because God's power has been granted, we make the effort…
  A. To exhibit Christian virtues
    1. Virtue
    2. Knowledge
    3. Self-control
    4. Steadfastness
    5. Godliness
    6. Brotherly love
    7. Love (agape)
  B. To guard against stagnant growth
    1. Or we will be ineffective and unfruitful
    2. We will forget…
      i. That we once saw (understood the gospel and responded)
      ii. That God cleansed us of our sins
  C. To be diligent to…
    1. Confirm our calling and election (salvation)
    2. Understand that these qualities are our surety to keep from falling
    3. Know God will welcome us richly into the Eternal Kingdom

The above outline represents a limited amount of time spent constructing it. It only took me about ten minutes to make a first-draft outline. If one were to sit down and really polish it up, it could be much more detailed and taught in Sunday School or a sermon over a period of several weeks. Keep in mind, also, that not every main clause has to be a main point. As you can see from above, I combined verses 5-11 under the main thought of making every effort. It still follows the flow of the text in that Peter gives a reason by using the phrase *for the reason* at the beginning of verse 5. Even you are not a regular teacher or preacher, get into the habit of outlining your study. It is extremely helpful. Simply follow the flow of thought to create your main points and any sub points.

Our initial outline is complete but our study is far from finished. The student should not stop here, for there is still much to glean from the fields. Our next step is to take the passage as a whole, using your guided outline, and to write a brief summary statement of the entire passage. Try to include the main points in your summary. Write it in your own words. This will ensure that you truly understand the main gist of the passage.

Summary Statement: As believers we have God's very own power to live a righteous and godly life. This power enables us to continually grow in our faith with God's own virtues, which seven are specifically mentioned. Caution is given however, to not become stagnant. If we fail to possess these qualities, Peter tells us two things: (1) we are blind, and (2) we have forgotten that we were cleansed of our past sins. This drives us to guard against stagnation with all diligence (confirming our calling & election) so that we will be richly welcomed into eternity to be with Christ.

Our summary statement above is concise and to the point. I've included both main points from the outline and some of the sub points to help flesh it out. After the summary statement is written, the real study begins. This is where the student would dig a little deeper with word studies in the original languages, more background study of the book or pericope, and re-writing the outline for a final format. If needed, you should re-write your summary statement to reflect the changes in your outline.

We continue with our study of this passage.

Exposition Example[12]

The next step is to analyze the passage and find the main point. It should not be what you ***think*** the main point is, but what the text says the main point is. A personal example was that upon my initial study of this passage, I honed in on verse 3, tagging the first main clause as the main point. Further study led me to conclude this false, even though God's divine power is the cause of all we do.

If you need a refresher on how to find the main point go back to that section **here**. Remembering that imperatives have priority, we note two imperatives in this section. They are *supplement your faith* and *be diligent to confirm your calling and election.* The phrase with *supplement* looks like an infinitive in English. It is not. According to the original Greek, it is actually an imperative. This can be confirmed by using any number of free bible study sites online. For your convenience, a list of these sites will be given at the end of this tutorial.

They are given equal weight and the rest of the passage hinges on these two imperatives. A close read reveals that the majority of this pericope elaborates on the possession and lack of these Christian qualities. Peter then concludes this thought with a warning and exhortation. The warning should cause us pause for reflection if these qualities are not present within our lives. The exhortation is that those who do possess

[12] This exposition is not comprehensive. It is only intended as an example. For this reason it is kept brief and concise. A more detailed analysis should be given by the student through word studies, further diagramming, and a rewriting of both the outline and summary statements.

these qualities in increasing measure, i.e., they are continuing to grow, will be welcomed into the Kingdom of Christ.

Great care must be taken at this juncture lest we risk perverting the gospel. Peter is not giving his audience a litmus test in order to see if they are truly saved. The complimentary infinitive completes the imperative of supplementing our faith, but with eagerness. The word used for 'eager' means to have zeal or a conscientious effort in your obligations of your duties.[13] Peter is warning his audience that a lack of these things is cause to confirm your salvation, not to doubt it. It is all too easy to break out our "check lists" and begin condemning ourselves if we don't hit every bullet on the list. Peter's warning is not to check off a list but to be conscientious of these qualities as a whole, as Giese points to the fact that this infinitive is attached to an imperative of the middle voice, resulting in a translation of confirming your election for your own benefit.[14] The idea is that we are eager and our attitude is to continue to grow these qualities which God's power has granted to us.

The attendance of these Christian qualities finds its result in the last concluding main statement: *For in this way there will be richly provided…an entrance.*The result lends itself to two specific things. They are an advantage, and a location, or as could also be labeled, a destination.

First, the advantage is for you. However, we must not be so quick to make this an all inclusive application. It is a specific 'you' which Peter has previously mentioned in verse 8. The advantage is only for who possess the divine power of God and taken hold of the qualities that mark a Christian. If you read the list of qualities carefully, you will notice that the first thing to furnish our faith with is virtue. This is the same word Peter uses in verse 4 to describe God's virtue, translated as 'excellence.' It also happens to be what Peter describes as part of our calling. We are called to be virtuous just as God is virtuous. Without that virtue, none of the other qualities can exist.

If the advantage is limited in its application, the second aspect of the result must also be limited by its implication. The destination is the Kingdom of Christ. Peter describes this kingdom briefly as eternal. It is a kingdom without end, just as predicted by the prophets and promised to David by God that an heir of his should never fail to sit on the Throne. This eternal Kingdom is within the presence of Jesus, who is the very embodiment of this virtue that His followers seek diligently and with all eagerness to increase in. The final words of Peter in the opening of this epistle is meant to encourage his audience to continue to pursue righteousness until the day we enter into God's presence. The rest of Peter's letter will be a warning against false teachers and godless living. For now, he desires his flock to be at peace and to continue to grow in their faith as they practice the qualities given them by God's divine power.

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[13] BDAG gives this definition for this very verse. The Louw-Nida dictionary also gives the definition of eagerness in attitude.

[14] Giese, C. P. (2012). *2 Peter and Jude, pp. 44-45.* (D. O. Wenthe & C. P. Giese, Eds.). Concordia Publishing House.

Closing Thoughts

Block diagramming is a wonderful tool to study God's word. It can take a long, wordy passage and expose the main thoughts with just a glance. Keep in mind that just as with any other skill you learn, this too must be practiced regularly in order to hone it to perfection. A few cautionary words to ponder is necessary at this point.

1. Do not let this method be your be-all-end-all for study. In other words, it is your duty as a student of God's divine word to continue to drill down deep and discover the riches of your particular passage.
2. Remain vigilant to not interpret the passage based on limited study. This is common for passages that are familiar. Even if you've read the passage a hundred times, make sure your interpretation and application are in line with what the texts states rather than looking for what you want or think it says.
3. Learn to use the tools God has richly provided for us in this modern age. The internet is a wonderful place to find free bible software, word study tools, commentaries, and all things related to bible study. In the day of the Information Highway, there is no excuse why we cannot be diligent in study or ignorant of God's word.
4. On point number three above, don't get in the habit of running to commentaries first. Do your own work and then check your commentary sources. The experience will be richer for you and you will learn to study better by holding off on reading another's exposition until you do your own.

And so our journey comes to an end. I pray this tutorial has been most fruitful and beneficial for you. May it enrich your own understanding of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Amen!

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